

Hoatzin

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Opisthocomiformes
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	1

A vegetarian bird of seasonally flooded forest, the colorful hoatzin uses its broad wings and long tail to balance elegantly while reaching for food in dense foliage. Fermentation of food in its stomach lends it the distinctive smell of rotting leaves.

NOISY BUNCH
Movements, such as wing-spreading, are often associated with loud hisses and grunts.



Opisthocomus hoazin

Hoatzin



Length	24–28 in (62–70 cm)
Weight	25–32 oz (700–900 g)
Plumage	Sexes alike
Migration	Nonmigrant
Status	Least concern

Location N. South America



This primitive-looking, tree-dwelling bird feeds almost entirely on leaves, a feat few other species can accomplish, because its large stomach enables it

to process plant material in a similar way to grazing mammals. The young leave the nest before they can fly and use their tiny wing claws to climb through vegetation; they dive into water if threatened. As many as 8 birds may live together, defending their common territory and helping to rear the young.



Turacos

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Musophagiformes
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	23

Turacos and go-away birds (named from their calls) make a distinct group with similarities in form and behavior. Turacos are colorful birds of forest canopies, and go-away birds are generally smaller, duller, and grayer species of bushy savanna.

LIVINGSTONE'S TURACO
This common turaco is found in evergreen forests of southeast Africa.



Tauraco erythrolophus

Red-crested turaco



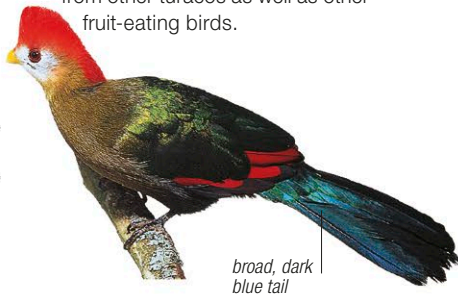
Length	16–17 in (40–43 cm)
Weight	7–12 oz (200–325 g)
Plumage	Sexes alike
Migration	Nonmigrant
Status	Least concern

Location S.W. Africa



Like other turacos, this species derives its bright colors from a copper-based pigment, unique to the turaco family. A tree-dwelling fruit-eater, it spends most

of its time hopping from branch to branch, and has a heavy, labored flight. It usually lives in family groups, foraging in the rain forest canopy and vigorously defending both feeding and nesting sites from other turacos as well as other fruit-eating birds.



broad, dark blue tail

Cuckoos

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Cuculiformes
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	149

Cuckoos are characterized by short, curved bills; tapered wings; a long tail—often drooped or swayed to help balance—and “zygodactyl” feet, with two toes forward, two back. Mostly arboreal, several are ground birds, and many drop to the ground to catch prey.

COMMON CUCKOO
Although widespread, the numbers of these birds are plummeting in farmland areas.



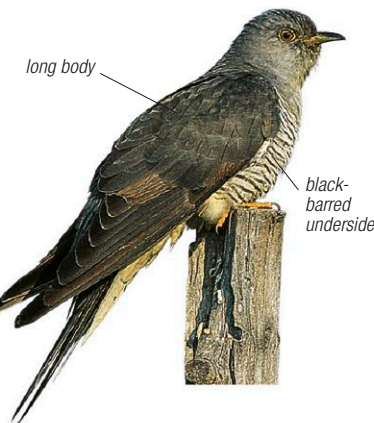
Cuculus canorus

Common cuckoo



Length	12¼–13 in (32–33 cm)
Weight	4 oz (125 g)
Plumage	Sexes alike
Migration	Migrant
Status	Least concern

Location Europe, Asia, N.W. and southern Africa



long body

black-barred underside

Geococcyx californianus

Greater roadrunner



Length	22 in (56 cm)
Weight	12 oz (325 g)
Plumage	Sexes alike
Migration	Nonmigrant
Status	Least concern

Location S. North America



Although it can fly, this long-legged member of the cuckoo family spends most of its time on the ground. Over short distances it can reach speeds of more than 18 mph (30 kph). It walks and runs through the desert, trying to flush out prey—lizards, snakes, birds, and small mammals—and kills whatever it catches with a blow from its strong, pointed bill. This roadrunner also runs to avoid predators, swinging its long tail from side to side like a rudder to make turns while speeding.



heavily streaked body

Clamator glandarius

Great spotted cuckoo



Length	14–15½ in (35–39 cm)
Weight	4 oz (125 g)
Plumage	Sexes alike
Migration	Migrant
Status	Least concern

Location S. Europe, W. Asia, Africa



The largest cuckoo found in Europe, this handsome bird lays its eggs in the nests of crows, magpies, and starlings.

Unlike common cuckoos, the young do not evict their nest-mates. However, since they grow faster than the other chicks, they get a larger share of the food brought by the foster parents, with the result that within the first 8 days of their life they reach half their fledgling weight.

white markings on back

